

Automation isn't magic.

It's consistency.

What actually happened after the flows went live — including the part nobody warns you about.

99%

of runs completed
without anyone touching
them

1%

was a person or a
dropped connection

0

times it forgot, got
tired, or went on leave

the hard part was never the tool

Everything has to be defined. Everything.

The tool will not infer what you meant. It does precisely what you described, including the parts you described badly.

WHAT YOU WROTE

“When the invoice arrives, file it and tell the approver.”

WHAT IT ASKS

Which mailbox? What counts as an invoice? Which approver? What if there are two? What if none?

Every unanswered question becomes a silent default.

So the real first step is not opening the tool:

write the SOP

do it by hand

then automate

Start with the manual work. Always.

Not because it is thorough. Because you cannot describe a process you have never personally done end to end.

1

Do it by hand, once

you will find three steps nobody documented

2

Write the work instruction

if you cannot write it, you cannot build it

3

Hand it to someone else

their questions are exactly the flow's edge cases

4

Only now, open the tool

the build is the fast part — it always was

Skipping to step four is why most automation projects stall.

It ran. Almost every time.

100 RUNS

completed, unattended

1%

The interesting part is what that 1% actually was.

CAUSE A

A person triggered it wrong

wrong file, wrong folder, right intention

CAUSE B

The connection dropped

the network, not the logic

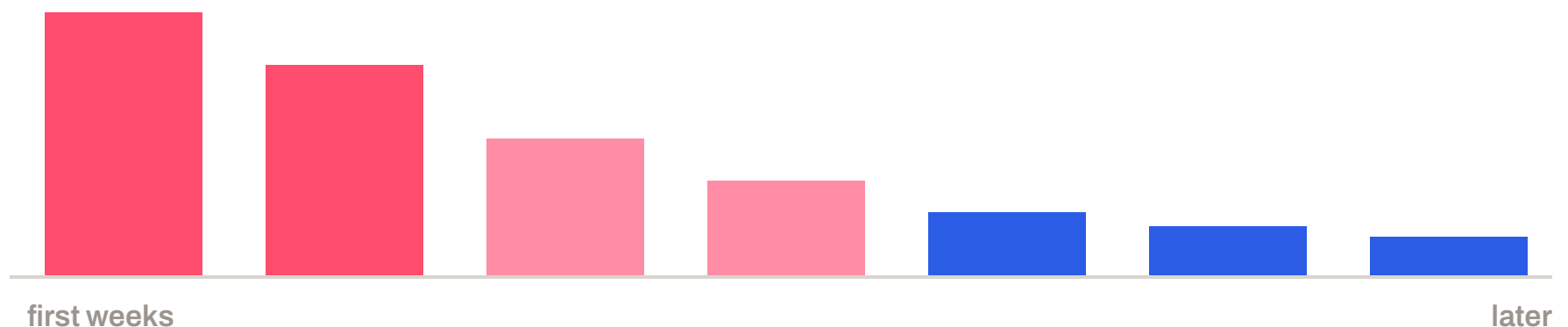
Not once did it fail because the logic was wrong. That part had already been argued out on paper.

Which tells you where to spend the effort: not on clever error handling, but on making the trigger hard to get wrong.

The requests went down, not up.

I expected a queue. Once colleagues saw a flow hold up week after week, they stopped asking for variations and started trusting the one that existed.

CHANGE REQUESTS, OVER TIME



WHAT I THOUGHT IT MEANT

“They've lost interest.”

WHAT IT ACTUALLY MEANT

“It already works. Leave it alone.”

Silence from users is ambiguous. Check which kind you have.

It does not buy you

cleverness.

It buys you

**the same result, on
a bad Tuesday.**

Reliability is unglamorous, and it is the entire product.

UP FRONT

Defining the rules. Testing the edges. Writing it down.

EVERY WEEK AFTER

It runs. You are not involved.
Nothing is forgotten.

It doesn't replace the person. It replaces the forgetting.

TAKEAWAY

Define clearly. Automate consistently. Then leave it alone.

The build is the short part. The describing is the work.

Write it before you build it

or it defines itself

Harden the trigger, not the logic

that's where the 1% lives

Quiet users may be happy users

but go and check

Which repetitive task could you define today?